

- RAG Learning

1.3 Electoral Systems

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 1: UK Politics, Section A

This topic is the most technical in Component 1 and the most rewarding, because almost every other question in UK Politics has an electoral-system component. Party systems, minor-party failure, the democratic deficit and the two-party debate all reduce to how votes are converted into seats. Learn the mechanics precisely: examiners can tell immediately whether a candidate understands how AMS or STV actually works.

First-past-the-post (FPTP) — single-member constituencies; the candidate with the most votes wins, with no majority required.

Additional Member System (AMS) — hybrid: single-member constituencies elected by FPTP plus a regional top-up list.

Single Transferable Vote (STV) — multi-member constituencies; voters rank candidates; surpluses and eliminations are transferred until a quota is met.

Supplementary Vote (SV) — voters express a first and second preference; used for mayors and PCCs until the Elections Act 2022, and restored for them from June 2026.

Safe seat — a constituency the same party wins consistently by a wide margin.

Marginal seat — a constituency where the gap between the leading candidates is narrow enough that it may change hands.

Minority government — a government without an overall Commons majority.

Coalition government — two or more parties agreeing to govern together and share ministerial office.

Wasted vote — one cast for a losing candidate, or surplus to the number the winner required.

Exam Tip: Keep the dates straight. The **Elections Act 2022** replaced **SV** with **FPTP** for elected mayors and police and crime commissioners from May 2023; the **English Devolution and Community Empowerment Act 2026** restored **SV** for those elections

from June 2026. The Senedd also changed: from May 2026 it is elected by **closed-list PR** (96 members, 16 six-member constituencies), not AMS.

1. Different electoral systems

System	How it works	Where used	Type
FPTP	One member per constituency; most votes wins	UK general elections; English and Welsh local elections; mayors and PCCs May 2023–May 2026	Plurality
AMS	Two votes: constituency (FPTP) and regional list; list seats top up to improve proportionality	Scottish Parliament, London Assembly; the Senedd until 2026 (closed-list PR since)	Hybrid / mixed
STV	Multi-member constituencies; ranked preferences; Droop quota; surpluses and eliminations transferred	Northern Ireland Assembly and local elections; Scottish local elections	Proportional
SV	First and second preference; if no majority, all but the top two eliminated and second preferences added	Mayors and PCCs, 2000–2023	Majoritarian

FPTP in detail

Advantages	Disadvantages
Usually produces a single-party majority, giving clear accountability and a government able to act on its mandate	Substantial disproportionality between vote share and seat share

Strong constituency link — one identifiable member per area, removable by that electorate	Large numbers of wasted votes: cast for losers, or surplus to the winner's requirement
Simple to understand and to count, which supports confidence in the result	Safe seats reduce competition and depress turnout
Historically kept parties with dispersed extremist support out of the Commons	Encourages tactical voting rather than sincere preference
Governments can be removed entire at a general election, without post-election bargaining	Governments routinely formed on 35–45% of the vote
Speedy formation of government — a new PM can take office the day after polling	Campaigning concentrates on a small number of marginal seats

Disproportionality: the evidence

Election	Illustration
2015	UKIP 12.6% of the vote → 1 seat. SNP 4.7% → 56 seats. Conservatives 36.9% → an overall majority
2005	Labour won a majority of 66 on 35.2% of the vote — the lowest winning share of the modern era
2019	Conservatives 43.6% → 365 seats (56% of the Commons); Lib Dems 11.6% → 11 seats
1983	SDP–Liberal Alliance 25.4% → 23 seats; Labour 27.6% → 209 seats
1951	Labour won more votes than the Conservatives and fewer seats — the plurality winner lost
February 1974	Same again: the Conservatives led on votes, Labour on seats; a hung parliament followed

The 1951 and February 1974 cases are worth knowing because they show the distortion is not merely a matter of degree: FPTP can reverse the order of the two largest parties entirely.

AMS in detail

Voters cast two votes. The constituency vote elects a member by FPTP; the regional vote is for a party list, and list seats are allocated so that each party's *overall* regional representation more closely reflects its regional vote share. In Scotland, **73 constituency members and 56 regional members** across eight regions; in Wales, 40 constituency and 20 regional under the arrangements in force for most of the devolution period.

The correction is partial rather than complete, which is why AMS is called a hybrid. A party that wins most constituency seats receives few list seats, because the calculation offsets what it already holds.

Strengths	Weaknesses
Markedly more proportional than FPTP while keeping a constituency link	Creates two classes of member with different mandates and workloads
Voters can split the ticket — supporting a constituency candidate and a different party regionally	List members are chosen by the party, not the voter, under a closed list
Gives smaller parties realistic representation	Coalition or minority government becomes the norm, so the governing programme is settled after the election

Scotland's record illustrates the range of outcomes: a Labour–Lib Dem coalition, SNP minority governments, an SNP overall majority in 2011 which the system was designed to make unlikely, and later an SNP–Green co-operation agreement.

STV in detail

Voters rank candidates in multi-member constituencies. A candidate is elected on reaching the

Droop quota:

$$\text{quota} = \left(\frac{\text{total valid votes}}{\text{seats} + 1} \right) + 1$$

Surplus votes above the quota transfer at a reduced value to later preferences; the lowest-placed candidates are eliminated and their votes transferred, until all seats are filled. In a six-seat constituency the quota is therefore just over one-seventh of the vote — which is why a party with modest but real support wins representation.

In Northern Ireland the purpose is structural. Multi-member seats and transfers ensure both communities are represented in every area, which makes the Good Friday Agreement's power-sharing executive consistent with the electoral outcome. It also gives candidates an incentive to seek transfers beyond their own community — though in practice transfers have often stayed within blocs.

Strengths	Weaknesses
Highly proportional; very few wasted votes	Weaker constituency link — several members serve one area, so responsibility is diffused
Voters choose between candidates of the same party, not just between parties	Complex count taking several days
Encourages candidates to appeal beyond their core support	Intra-party competition can create friction between colleagues
Almost always produces coalition, which requires broad agreement	Coalition may deliver a programme no voter actually chose

SV in detail

Voters mark a first and a second preference. If a candidate wins more than 50% of first preferences they are elected. Otherwise all but the top two are eliminated, and the second preferences of eliminated candidates' voters are added where they name one of the remaining two. It produces a winner with broad rather than merely plurality support, but only among those whose second preference happened to fall on a survivor — many ballots are exhausted. The Elections Act 2022 replaced it with FPTP from May 2023, a change its critics argued would advantage the largest party; the English Devolution and Community Empowerment Act 2026 brought it back from June 2026.

2. Referendums and how they are used

Year	Question	Turnout	Result
1975	Remain in the EEC	64.0%	67.2% Yes
1979	Scottish / Welsh devolution	63.6% / 58.8%	Scotland Yes but below the 40% threshold; Wales No
1997	Scottish Parliament / Welsh Assembly	60.2% / 50.1%	74.3% Yes / 50.3% Yes
1998	Good Friday Agreement	81.1%	71.1% Yes
2011	Alternative Vote	42.2%	67.9% No
2014	Scottish independence	84.6%	55.3% No
2016	EU membership	72.2%	51.9% Leave

Referendums have been used almost exclusively for **constitutional** questions — a convention rather than a rule, since nothing prevents one on any subject. The 2011 AV referendum repays detailed knowledge: it was conceded by the Conservatives as the price of coalition, AV is not itself a proportional system, turnout was low at 42.2%, and the decisive rejection has been treated as settling the wider reform question for a generation. A campaign framing reform as a preoccupation of politicians was central to the outcome.

Arguments

For	Against
Direct legitimacy for constitutional change that a parliamentary vote cannot supply	Reduces a complex, multi-dimensional question to a binary
Entrenchment by consent — prevents a temporary majority altering the settlement for advantage	Advisory in law, binding in practice — authority with no rules attached

High participation: 84.6% in Scotland in 2014	Vulnerable to campaign spending, misinformation and mid-term protest voting
Settles questions that cut across party lines and so cannot be resolved at a general election	A narrow result can bind a deeply divided country indefinitely
Educative — campaigns generate sustained public engagement with constitutional questions	No settled rules on thresholds, franchise, or when a question may be asked again

3. Electoral system analysis

Comparing the systems

Criterion	FPTP	AMS	STV	SV
Proportionality	Low	Moderate to high	High	Low
Constituency link	Strong	Mixed — two classes of member	Weaker — several members per area	Strong
Voter choice	One candidate	Party and candidate separately	Between candidates of the same party	Two preferences
Likely government	Single-party majority	Coalition or minority	Coalition	Single office-holder
Wasted votes	Very high	Reduced	Low	High — many ballots exhausted
Simplicity	High	Moderate	Low	Moderate

Effects on party systems within the UK

The same country running different systems is an unusually clean natural experiment, and it is the strongest evidence available in this topic. Proportional rules in Scotland and Wales convert support that FPTP suppresses into seats, so smaller parties such as the Greens hold representation at Holyrood that Westminster arithmetic denies them. Coalition and minority government have been normalised there, which directly weakens a central argument for FPTP — that only it delivers stable government. Northern Ireland's STV sustains a wholly separate multi-party system.

Turnout and safe seats

Roughly half of Westminster seats change hands very rarely. Turnout is consistently lower in safe seats than in marginals, and campaign resources flow overwhelmingly to the few dozen genuinely competitive constituencies. The consequence extends beyond fairness to *governing*: policy attention follows the voters who can change the outcome, which is a distortion distinct from disproportionality and arguably more serious.

Why has Westminster not changed?

- **Self-interest.** The parties able to legislate the change are the ones FPTP advantages.
- **The 2011 result.** Rejected 67.9% to 32.1% on 42% turnout.
- **Genuine attachment to the status quo.** Decisive government and the constituency link are real goods, and there is no sustained public demand for change.
- **No trigger.** Reform tends to follow a hung parliament in which a smaller party extracts it as a condition — exactly how the AV referendum arose, and its failure removed the mechanism.
- **The Jenkins Commission (1998)** recommended AV Plus after a Labour manifesto commitment to a referendum. With a majority of 179 (177 on the stricter count that treats the Speaker as Labour — both figures are in circulation), the government had no incentive to proceed, and it did not.

The circularity is worth stating explicitly: FPTP produces majorities that make reform unnecessary for the governing party, so the system protects itself.

Exam Tip: For "Evaluate the case for reforming the Westminster electoral system" (30 marks, AO1/AO2/AO3 10 each), the judgement should turn on what elections are *for*. If they exist to choose and remove a government, FPTP performs well. If they exist to represent the distribution of opinion, it performs badly. The two purposes genuinely conflict, and saying so

is the conclusion — not a failure to reach one. Use the devolved systems as evidence rather than speculation.

Quick recall

- FPTP (Westminster, English locals) · AMS (Holyrood, London; Senedd until 2026) · closed list (Senedd from 2026) · STV (NI, Scottish locals) · SV (mayors and PCCs to 2023, again from June 2026)
- 2015: UKIP 12.6% = 1 seat; SNP 4.7% = 56. 2005: a majority on 35.2%
- 1951 and Feb 1974: the party with more votes won fewer seats
- AMS Scotland = 73 constituency + 56 regional; correction is partial, hence "hybrid"
- STV Droop quota = $(\text{votes} \div (\text{seats} + 1)) + 1$; in NI it underwrites power-sharing
- 1979 is the only turnout threshold used — and it voided a Yes vote
- 2011 AV: rejected 67.9–32.1 on 42.2% turnout; Jenkins (1998) recommended AV Plus and was shelved
- Devolved proportional systems are the natural experiment against FPTP's stability claim
- Judgement: accountability against representativeness — the two purposes conflict